



Above The 7th-century rock-hewn monuments of Pancha Rathas in Mamallapuram have been designated a UNESCO World Heritage site

Left The Nataraja temple in Chidambaram is one of the most ancient and celebrated shrines in India

What Else to Eat

Places that serve thalis tend also to offer a range of tasty south Indian snacks at certain times of day, generally from early morning until around 11 AM and then again from early evening until the restaurant closes. The most delicious snack option is **masala dosa**, a crispy rice-flour pancake stuffed with a lightly spiced potato and onion curry called **sabji**. *Masala dosa* is always accompanied by **sambar**, one of the sauces that comes with a thali, and coconut chutney. These two side dishes also accompany other popular snacks, such as **idli** (disk-shaped rice cakes) and **vada** (lentil and rice-flour savory doughnuts).



Above The vegetarian meal of thali consists of many small dishes and aromatic sauces served alongside rice on a banana leaf

The Best Places to Eat Thali

Golden Palate moderate

The beautifully decorated and pleasantly air-conditioned vegetarian dining room of the Mamalla Heritage hotel in Mamallapuram continues the tradition started by the Mamalla Bhavan, the original village restaurant here, which still pulls in the crowds just up the road by the bus stand. At the Golden Palate, however, a little comfort and attentive service is added to the raw experience of thali-eating in most Tamil venues. Although eating with the hand is still the norm, you won't stick out if you opt for a spoon because many foreigners eat here.

The food itself has the reputation of being some of the best in northeast Tamil Nadu, and it is delicately prepared by a team of knowledgeable chefs. Some of the revolving selection of curry dishes that accompany the thali are not found elsewhere, such as okra with mustard seeds and beans cooked in a bright yellow turmeric sauce. The standard dishes – such as *sambar* and *rasam* – are as good as you'll find anywhere.

104 East Raja Street, Mamallapuram; open 7 AM–10 PM daily; www.hotelmamallaheritage.com

Also in Tamil Nadu

Sri Ganesh Bhavan (*inexpensive*) on West Car Street, Chidambaram, backing on to the temple, is a quintessential thali haunt, with just a few creaky tables but superb fresh food. The food-only **Aakash Hotel** (*inexpensive*), next to the bus stand in Tiruvannamalai, is another great spot to get a filling banana-leaf buffet. The **Saravana Bhavan** chain (www.saravanabhavan.com; *inexpensive*), which has branches throughout Chennai and other parts of the state, is also highly recommended.

Also in India

Mysore's food-only **Hotel RRR** (+91 821 244 2878; *inexpensive*) does some of the best vegetarian thalis in Karnataka, while in Kerala's state capital, Trivandrum, top thalis can be had at **Hotel Arya Niwas** (+91 471 233 0789; *inexpensive*). Delhi, the nation's capital, has a worthy northern outpost for south Indian fare in the very good **Anand** (+91 11 2331 3554; *inexpensive*) on Connaught Lane, a simple place that serves wonderful chicken delicacies.

Around the World

Although the great majority of curry houses outside India serve predominantly north Indian cuisine, there are still fine thalis to be found. Among over 10,000 Indian restaurants in the UK are six London branches of **Chennai Dosa** (www.chennaidosa.com; *inexpensive*), where you can find authentic thalis, *dosas*, and other south Indian snacks.